The most eloquently argued case against a surprise attack was provided to the President by George Ball, Under-Secretary of State, on 18 October.[38] Ball accepted the blockade option was 'unsatisfactory – primarily because it does not provide a way to prevent the Soviet missiles from becoming operational' (though he did not consider that sufficient to reject the idea). Starting with the assumption that missiles in Cuba did not appreciably add to the Soviets' 'ability to impose destruction on the United States,' he argued:

> We tried Japanese as war criminals because of the sneak attack on Pearl Harbor. We condemned the Soviet action in Hungary. We took a strong moral line against the use of force by the French and British at Suez when they felt their vital interests were threatened. We have taken a strong line in the United Nations and in other World Councils against the dangers of a surprise attack with nuclear weapons.
>
> It is my strongly held view that we cannot launch a surprise attack against Cuba without destroying our moral position and alienating our friends and allies. If we were to do so we would wake up the following morning to find that we had brought down in ruins the structure of alliances and arrangements, and that our whole post-war effort of trying to organise the combined strength of the Free World was in shards and tatters.[39]

Martin Sherwin argues that Kennedy had been persuaded of the blockade by the evening of Thursday, 18 October.[40] The following morning, he met with the Joint Chiefs, who made clear their opposition to the blockade and their support for an all-out attack and invasion. What impact did these (and other) arguments have on Kennedy? His original impulses favoured military action (as they did after the failure of the Bay of Pigs). As 'the tempers of the moment' cooled somewhat, JFK consulted, listened, and reflected on a variety of opinions.

ExComm provided a forum for debate and was later seen as indispensable in securing consensus within the administration. Not all were